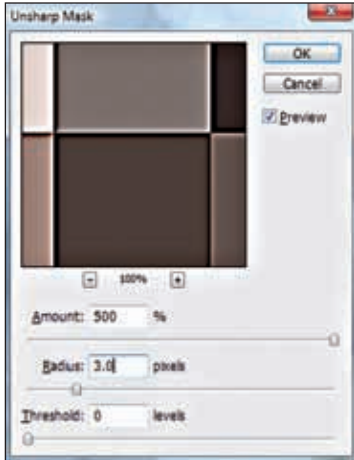


is used when you cannot afford to lose out on sharpness because of noise reduction, which works on the assumption that the noise in your image is truly random, and such random fluctuations above and below actual image data will gradually even out as one averages more and more images.



Example of using the unsharp mask

Neat Image is one of the easiest tools to implement the concept, or if you are an ardent Photoshop follower, it can be quickly done using layers, by stacking each image in a separate layer and blending them such that all contribute equally.

Sharpen your images

Now that most major aspects of the image have been taken into account, let us brush up on the details. Some of the first few steps in this are usually sharpening, clarity and local contrast adjustments. Image sharpening is a powerful tool for emphasizing texture and drawing viewer

focus. Digital camera sensors and lenses always blur image to some degree, requiring correction. Most image sharpening tools work by applying what is called an “un-sharp mask”, which works by exaggerating the brightness difference along the edges within an image. In Photoshop you can access the un-sharp mask by clicking on the following drop down menu: **Filter > Sharpen > Un-sharp Mask.**

On most software you’ll most probably have simple sliders to guide the level of sharpness. An ideal way to go about is by taking it all the way up or down and trying to see what difference it makes to your image. A few experiments like this will give you a good feel of what an optimal sharpness value is, where the delicate balance can be achieved between making edges appear sufficiently pronounced while also minimizing visible under overshoots (called “sharpening halos”). There are fairly standard sharpening settings in almost all photo editing software, including radius, amount and threshold (masking). “Radius” here controls the size of the edges that are being enhanced, thus a smaller radius will be enhancing small scale details, and you’ll generally want a radius setting comparable to the size